

A class suit

Of the 16 class-action suits alleging unlawful wielding of its monopoly by Microsoft, the largest of its kind has been successfully settled between the software giant and the government of California. The charge that Microsoft Windows was overcharged from the comfort of its monopolistic position, was settled on the requirement that the company will offer compensation to those affected between February 18, 1995 and December 15, 2001. The compensation will take the form of vouchers worth \$5 to \$29 that can be used to buy most hardware and software products from any manufacturer. Of the unclaimed money, one-third will be retained by Microsoft and two-thirds will go to California public schools in a mix of donated Microsoft software and cash grants.

Apple feels that such a settlement lets Microsoft off easy, pointing out that history shows that less than one-quarter of the qualifying recipients actually claim refunds, thereby reducing the real cost to Microsoft. At the same time, Apple said school donations would help Microsoft expand its market share in education—an area once dominated solely by Apple.

snapshot

680 million obsolete computers will produce **4 billion** pounds of plastic and **1 billion** pounds of lead in the next 5 years

Source: Silicon Valley Toxics Coalition

Born to consume

The annual Consumer Electronics Show saw technology being brought to the masses through handhelds, even as the PC gets comfortable as a central hub of information exchange. Significant attention was called upon Microsoft and its Smart Personal Object Technology (SPOT) as the software giant looks to appliances as a market. SPOT allows devices such as alarm clocks to run Microsoft's .Net Compact Framework and gain access to data stored on a central PC.

Also on the radar was Media2Go, a portable multimedia gadget design, jointly

developed by Microsoft and Intel. Media2Go devices will have a 4-inch screen, a hard drive and controls for listening to digital music, viewing photos and TV programmes downloaded from a PC.

Sony is expected to announce jointly with SanDisk, a new version of the Memory Stick removable flash memory card format, called Memory Stick Pro. The format will offer greater capacity (up to 1 GB) at a rumoured cost of compatibility with older devices.

Also offered was the \$800 Sony Clie PEG-NZ90—now with a 2-megapixel camera with flash, along with zoom and autofocus features.



Intel names mobile chip family

Intel's new range of next-generation mobile processor technology is going to be branded the Centrino. Centrino stems from a blend of the words 'centre' and 'neutrino', and with this new name and logo, Intel wants to convey flight and mobility.

Targeted at the so called thin and light notebooks, the processor itself, formerly called Banias, will now be called Pentium M. The Centrino range is scheduled to be unveiled around late March 2003, with the first Pentium M chips clocking in

at 1.4 GHz. Incidentally, the Pentium 4-M, the mobile processor version of the Pentium 4, currently runs at 2.2 GHz and newer variants are expected to run at 2.4 GHz. With the Pentium M running behind its older mobile sibling, Intel has integrated a larger cache and a few other tricks to narrow down the performance gap.

Intel insiders claim that the new chip offers significant advantages over the P4 Mobile chip, with extended battery life for the computing device, as well as enhanced wireless networking facility.



heroes

Streaming media

A new licensing plan from Microsoft will allow developers to create streaming software that will run on various Windows and non-Windows devices, opening up a wider market and thus, more access to varied streaming content.

Notebook computers

The first generation of desktop notebooks, offering features such as fast chips, big screens and DVD drives for relatively low prices, are selling surprisingly well. Buoyant manufacturers are launching the second generation of these machines.



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Content generators

With Windows XP Media Center Edition, which melds PVR hardware into PCs, users who have file-sharing programs like KaZaA aboard, will be able to swap as much recorded content as they like.

DirectTV

A Russian student in Los Angeles leaked out the details of the cards that access DirecTV programming to underground Web sites. People can now watch DirecTV for free.

Gamers

Games with no sex or violence will be rated age 3 plus, and there will be further ratings of 7 plus, 12 plus, 16 plus and 18 plus. All computer games sold in the European Union from April 2003 will carry these classifications